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THE MONUMENTS MUST GO: Reflecting on Opportunities for Campus Conversations
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THE MONUMENTS MUST GO

Reflecting on Opportunities for Campus Conversations

Note: The following letter appeared in Slate on August 16, 2017. We reprint this letter here with permission.

Dear Richmond Mayor Levar Stoney and members of the Monument Avenue Commission,

We are native Richmonders and also the great-great-grandsons of Stonewall Jackson. As two of the closest living relatives to Stonewall, we are writing today to ask for the removal of his statue, as well as the removal of all Confederate statues from Monument Avenue. They are overt symbols of racism and white supremacy, and the time is long overdue for them to depart from public display. Overnight, Baltimore has seen fit to take this action. Richmond should, too.

In making this request, we wish to express our respect and admiration for Mayor Stoney's leadership while also strongly disagreeing with his claim that "removal of symbols does [nothing] for telling the actual truth [nor] changes the state and culture of racism in this country today." In our view, the removal of the Jackson statue and others will necessarily further difficult conversations about racial justice. It will begin to tell the truth of us all coming to our senses.

Last weekend, Charlottesville showed us unequivocally that Confederate statues offer pre-existing iconography for racists. The people who descended on Charlottesville last weekend were there to make a naked show of force for white supremacy. To them,

The letter then has functioned as a public display of white-unburdening, one that is celebrated and even envied by similarly burdened, similarly progressive white people.

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the Robert E. Lee statue is a clear symbol of their hateful ideology. The Confederate statues on Monument Avenue are, too—especially Jackson, who faces north, supposedly as if to continue the fight.

We are writing to say that we understand justice very differently from our grandfather's grandfather, and we wish to make it clear his statue does not represent us.

Through our upbringing and education, we have learned much about Stonewall Jackson. We have learned about his reluctance to fight and his teaching of Sunday School to enslaved peoples in Lexington, Virginia, a potentially criminal activity at the time. We have learned how thoughtful and loving he was toward his family. But we cannot ignore his decision to own slaves, his decision to go to war for the Confederacy, and, ultimately, the fact that he was a white man fighting on the side of white supremacy.

While we are not ashamed of our great-great-grandfather, we are ashamed to benefit from white supremacy while our black family and friends suffer. We are ashamed of the monument.

In fact, instead of lauding Jackson's violence, we choose to celebrate Stonewall's sister—our great-great-grandaunt—Laura Jackson Arnold. As an adult Laura became a staunch Unionist and abolitionist. Though she and Stonewall were incredibly close through childhood, she never spoke to Stonewall after his decision to support the Confederacy. We choose to stand on the right side of history with Laura Jackson Arnold.

Confederate monuments like the Jackson statue were never intended as benign symbols. Rather, they were the clearly articulated artwork of white supremacy. Among many examples, we can see this plainly if we look at the dedication of a Confederate statue at the University of North Carolina, in which a speaker proclaimed that the Confederate soldier "saved the very life of the Anglo-Saxon race in the South." Disturbingly, he went on to recount a tale of performing the "pleasing duty" of "horse whipping" a black woman in front of federal soldiers. All over the South, this grotesque message is conveyed by similar monuments. As importantly, this message is clear to today's avowed white supremacists.

There is also historical evidence that the statues on Monument Avenue were rejected by black Richmonders at the time of their construction. In the 1870s, John Mitchell, a black city councilman, called the monuments a tribute to "blood and treason" and voiced strong opposition to the use of public funds for building them. Speaking about the Lee Memorial, he vowed that there would come a time when African Americans would "be there to take it down."

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Ongoing racial disparities in incarceration, educational attainment, police brutality, hiring practices, access to health care, and, perhaps most starkly, wealth, make it clear that these monuments do not stand somehow outside of history. Racism and white supremacy, which undoubtedly continue today, are neither natural nor inevitable. Rather, they were created in order to justify the unjustifiable, in particular slavery.

One thing that bonds our extended family, besides our common ancestor, is that many have worked, often as clergy and as educators, for justice in their communities. While we do not purport to speak for all of Stonewall's kin, our sense of justice leads us to believe that removing the Stonewall statue and other monuments should be part of a larger project of actively mending the racial disparities that hundreds of years of white supremacy have wrought. We hope other descendants of Confederate generals will stand with us.

As cities all over the South are realizing now, we are not in need of added context. We are in need of a new context—one in which the statues have been taken down.

Respectfully,
William Jackson Christian
Warren Edmund Christian
Great-great-grandsons of Thomas Jonathan "Stonewall" Jackson

WARREN: Since Jack and I released our open letter asking for the monument of our great-great-grandfather Confederate General Thomas "Stonewall" Jackson to be removed, many people have expressed concern over the feedback we must be receiving. While I have received lots of feedback, the overwhelming majority has been positive. The few negative emails I have received have been mostly cordial, and none has come close to bordering on threats. This is a far cry from what Takiyah Thompson, who scaled a Confederate statue in Durham, North Carolina, looped a rope around its neck, and let the crowd "decide if they wanted to pull it down or not" has faced (Democracy Now). While the white privilege Jack and I enjoy has allowed our dissent to be tolerated even by people who disagree with us, Thompson has been subjected to racist white rage—both from individuals and from the state. She was denied service at a Durham bar, received death threats from white nationalists, and faced felony charges. Many well-wishers have praised our courage in speaking out; however, this pales in comparison to Thompson's bravery. Her act

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was also much more effective. The monument in Durham is down while the Stonewall statue in Richmond does not appear to be going anywhere anytime soon.

I owe Takiyah Thompson and the other courageous Durham activists a debt of gratitude because it was their act of revolutionary democracy that sparked our letter. I attended the rally at the Durham courthouse that preceded the toppling of the Confederate monument. My partner and I listened to a few speeches, and then we got hungry and bored, so we went to eat. The fairly small, peaceful protest we witnessed is totally at odds with the felony charges of inciting a riot that Thompson and others faced. It was by no means a riot. While we were eating near the courthouse, my partner saw on social media that the statue had just been toppled. We gathered a few friends and raced to the scene. We spent a moment celebrating and paying our disrespect to the crumpled symbol of white supremacy that had stood guard in front of the courthouse making it clear exactly who could and could not expect to receive justice inside. Standing in front of the now grounded hollow statue, I have never felt so proud to be a resident of Durham. On the way home, I excitedly called Jack, who also called Durham home for a time, to spread the good news. In our elation, Jack and I decided it was finally time to take a public stand against Confederate monuments.

It was not long after I had started my graduate student career at the University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill that I learned of the context surrounding the erection of the Confederate statue Silent Sam that is mentioned in our letter. Since learning of Julian Carr's hate-filled and explicitly white supremacist dedication, I have been offended by the statue's presence on campus. I'd thought of writing a letter regarding Silent Sam for years, but I was wary of presuming that anyone gave a damn what an ancestor of a Confederate general thought about a monument and relying on the very privilege afforded by the white supremacy we seek to disrupt. Thompson's and others' direct action suggested to my brother and me that the time was ripe for removing these symbols of white supremacy. Jack and I hoped that, at the very least, advocates for monument removal would be able to use our letter in service of rebutting the common argument about heritage enlisted as support for the monuments.

Jack and I each crafted a separate letter that Monday—the same night that Thompson provided others the opportunity to pull down the statue in Durham. After an intensive process of combining our letters,

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editing, receiving input from our gracious partners, and rewriting, we settled on our final version Wednesday evening. A few hours later, it appeared on slate.com. On Thursday morning, Jack and I were guests on *Democracy Now!*

Since then, an unexpected response was how our letter has been taken up by university campuses as part of a larger conversation regarding Confederate monuments as well as monuments in general. In particular, Jack and I heard from other teachers—many people we knew and many who have reached out to us since August—who let us know they planned to use the letter in their classes. That our letter would be presented as a teaching tool was a welcome surprise. Since Jack and I are both educators and both engaged with teaching writing, we wanted to take a moment to offer our reflections on how our letter relates to the teaching contexts we inhabit. Jack will have more opportunity to work with the letter directly in his teaching; his experience informs the next section.

JACK: When Warren and I appeared on *Democracy Now!* in mid-August to discuss our letter, the host Amy Goodman, noting that we are both educators employed by universities, asked us what we would tell our students about our decision to write. The question came to me first and I said, "I don't know but I'm glad to have until September 6th to think about it" before Warren then gave a more thoughtful answer.

Two months later, the fall semester was in full swing. I was teaching four sections of first-year writing in my sixth year as a full-time temporary instructor, and I still didn't know quite how our letter should be best presented in my own—or others'—writing classes.

This is not to say my students were not very much on my mind in the days just after the white nationalist riots in Charlottesville that killed Heather Heyer. When I first saw pictures of young white nationalist demonstrators holding tiki torches, it was not hard to imagine my own students, who are overwhelmingly white, as being part of the crowd. So many of the protesters looked, dressed, and walked like some of my students. They had similar posture and similar haircuts. To me, this connection was visceral, and whether it was fair or not, it was a connection I could not help but make.

This connection was then re-enforced when I read about Peter Cvjetanovic, whose image—in full-throated yell on the University of Virginia campus—was plastered immediately over the internet and

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television. After being identified in the photo, Cvjetanovic, a twenty-year-old University of Nevada student, made equivocating statements that being "pro-white" did not make him "anti-anybody else" (KTVN-TV). He tried also to claim that he had not known quite what he had gotten himself into. I'm not saying I buy Cvjetanovic's statements—particularly his claim that he just wanted to "see Richard Spencer," as if the spectacle could be absolved of politics—but what is interesting to me is that his statements and his apparent naiveté sounded in tone and content like the kind of excuses I sometimes hear from my own students. In turn, this makes me think more deeply about the ways in which teachers can and should intervene when students espouse racist ideology.

Asking this question has prompted me to remember that my first introduction to *Breitbart*, *InfoWars*, and other websites identifying themselves as "The Alt-Right" came from one of my students. In the spring of 2015, a student in my one of my first-year writing classes—I'll call him Toby—wrote a blatantly racist and woefully inadequate research essay that basically argued that most claims of police brutality were hoaxes. When I confronted him about this, I started by addressing his sources and the fact that they did not meet the criteria of being reputable news sites, a consideration that we had discussed in class. We looked together at reporting from the *New York Times* and elsewhere about the mission of sites like Breitbart, and I was able to ask him if these beliefs were his. He replied that they were not, but they did reflect the beliefs of his family members. About his family, he said, "They aren't really college people." In the end, I did not push back much on what appeared to be his own racism, but I did require him to rewrite his research essay with reputable sources.

And he did. In the end, it was still a marginal essay at best. His grade changed from an F to a C. I felt my intervention with him had been somewhat positive but also incomplete. We had a thirty-minute conversation, and then an even briefer one when I handed his paper back and complimented him for the effort he had put into his rewrite, which was both substantial and deserving of a higher grade. But what had he learned? He had maybe learned how to be a better researcher and that Breitbart and other similar sites would not fly as a secondary source in an academic class. If anything, he probably learned better to conceal his racist beliefs in future academic endeavors. I lamented that I had no real recourse to follow up with him, nowhere specific to send him except onward to

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sophomore year. This assignment and our discussion had taken place at the end of the semester. He had arrived poorly prepared for the work of our class, and he was leaving it only slightly better prepared to succeed in future writing situations. He was one of 75 students I had that semester. I had a good number of other students actively seeking me out for extra help, whereas with Toby it was clear that I would have to initiate all one-on-one discussions. On top of that, I was also in the process of attempting to get rehired—a process that consumed my time and attention—and incentivized me not to push too hard with students whom I needed to evaluate me positively, much less draw outside attention to the failings of my students.

It is in the context of this situation with Toby, my perpetual status as a contingent faculty member, and the imaginative connection I drew between my students and the Charlottesville protesters that I think about teaching our letter. First of all, I think my interaction with Toby highlights the necessity of foregrounding discussions about race and race issues in writing classes. All of the first-year writing classes I teach place an emphasis on being process-based, which means that instructors and students are to address the writing process first and foremost, while the topics about which students write take a back seat to our exploration to the work of drafting and revising. In Toby's class, we had focused on a variety of current events—from topics related to digital technology as well as current political debates. Many of these caused us to touch upon considerations of race, but none of which forced students to engage directly with it. I had, after all, encouraged my students to "write about what interests you." I think this is not just my own shortcoming but also a systemic problem of college writing courses as they are frequently taught to first and second year students all across the country. Historically, these courses have been used to teach rhetoric—an academic discipline that has seemingly been erased from first-year writing course design. In its place we are left with a pedagogy in which whatever subject matter is taken up is ultimately put to the service of learning and exploring the writing process. I think the current outburst of white nationalist violence is, among other things, a call to trouble the ubiquity of the process-based approach.

To me, it is clear how the process-based approach mediated my intervention with Toby. I spoke to him about improving the process by which he evaluated and chose sources. I felt uneasy addressing the racist

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content of his research essay directly because race and racism had not been an issue we had studied directly as a class. I did not want him to feel attacked, and I have always placed little stock in the efficacy of confrontations in changing a student's future thinking and behavior. It could be said that my class's indirect focus on the writing process allowed me to address Toby's racist attitudes in a less threatening and possibly more effective way. However, ultimately I find this rationale inadequate. The problem is, at its root, the process-based model would suggest that a racist essay that is well-written and researched should be evaluated the same as an anti-racist essay that is equally well-written and researched. It strikes me that this is almost precisely the logic exploited by the so-called alt-right and by the Trump Administration. This is the same logic that encourages Peter Cvjetanovic to claim being pro-white does not make him anti-anybody else, and it is the same logic by which President Trump could discuss the violence "on all sides" days after the Charlottesville protests.

Ultimately, these experiences have led me to reflect upon ways in which the neoliberal academy is complicit in producing such moral relativism, and most damningly on how the field of composition, in its goals to bring the processes of academic writing to traditional and non-traditional, well-prepared and ill-prepared students alike, has been so effectively co-opted by neoliberal moral relativism, and has been almost totally incapable of creating conditions, such as manageable course loads and permanent contracts, by which the writing process can be meaningfully and responsibly taught. I am not criticizing excellent research on the best practices for teaching freshman writing, nor am I criticizing my excellent colleagues who deal valiantly with this far-from-perfect situation. What I am criticizing is the conditions on the ground—i.e., the way in which the courses I am asked to teach, and the compromises necessary for me to be able to teach them, create a bastardized approach in which students are consumers, teachers are content providers, and race and racism become just one of the myriad banal matters a college writing class might or might not address.

For example, consider first-year writing's widely used textbook, W. W. Norton's *They Say/I Say*, which in its attempts at demystification, comes close to suggesting all writing is a game of Mad-Libs. According to *They Say/I Say*, the writer endeavors to locate and copy an already existing template for any specific genre. I have used this text in my courses, but in the last few years, I have stopped using it. This is because given

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the circumstances in which I teach, I find I barely have the time or the resources to even begin to complicate *They Say /I Say*'s troubling, transactional, paint-by-numbers approach.

In the three semesters since my interaction with Toby, I have made race a much more central topic in my classes. Texts such as bell hooks's "In Our Glory: Photography and Black Life," John Edgar Wideman's "Looking at Emmett Till," excerpts of Claudia Rankine's *Citizen*, Ta-Nehisi Coates's *Between the World and Me*, Vershawn Ashanti Young's "Should Writer's Use They Own English?" and various texts from publically available Black Lives Matter syllabuses have become mainstays of my teaching, as I have attempted to tie them to students' own investigations into, and critical reflections upon, their own experiences. In teaching texts such as these, I encounter my students' silence and am faced with the difficulty of unpacking the roots of this silence. I *think* it is a combination of many factors, including that they feel sick of talking about race and racism, that they feel the strictures of political correctness circumscribe the expression of their incomplete and complex thoughts, that they fear alienation from their peers, that they understand the concept of white privilege at the same time that they do not feel particularly privileged themselves, and, perhaps above all, that they have learned to separate their actual feelings and ideas from what they are willing to discuss in class. It may very well be that my students have learned a sophisticated rhetorical flexibility that they use to navigate such discussions. As such, they readily apply a concept I am tasked with teaching to their own goal of avoiding discomfort.

In this situation, I am not sure our letter makes for a good teaching tool after all. From other teachers, what I gather mostly is that it is being used to dramatize the process by which two white guys spoke up about their famous racist ancestor. Our claim to authority owes only to our blood relationship. In this way, our authority is constructed as the mirror opposite of any white person who finds identity and authority by participating in a white nationalist rally or writing on a white nationalist website. Moreover, our letter, while it drew much attention, has not played any role that I can see in hastening the removal of Confederate monuments in Richmond. Instead, we have been lauded for standing up as so-called allies speaking for racial justice. We have also experienced a strain of progressive back-patting in which it seems to me that what people admire is the chance Warren and I took to (briefly) unburden ourselves of our racist inheritance in a loud and public manner. The letter

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then has functioned as a public display of white-unburdening, one that is celebrated and even envied by similarly burdened, similarly progressive white people. My main reflection then is that we, mostly, and despite better intentions, preached to the choir and the choir applauded. What I will say to my students, and what I hope to demonstrate to them, is that they can construct their authority to write through reading and research, through talking to different people, by participating in communities, and by thinking critically about the communities in which they participate. In short, they can construct their authority to speak and write on important issues out of so much more than their genealogy. Our letter might be a starting point for helping students develop ethos, but it cannot be an ending point.

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